

SCIENCE / PHILOSOPHY / LIFE TOGETHER

RESPONSIBILITY

What We Owe a World
We Did Not Choose

From the Child Who Makes a Mistake
to the Question of God

*We are not the cause of all suffering.
But some suffering depends on what we do next.*

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Reading Note

Responsibility is discussed here as a problem of living together: what we can ask of one another and how we justify those demands. The book combines the history of ideas, psychological and sociological research, thought experiments, and moral arguments. Its history is selective; it does not assume a linear evolution from “primitive” cultures to a definitive morality.

Scenes without an identified historical source are hypothetical. They do not describe real people and should not be read as evidence of how frequently a behavior occurs. Their purpose is to reveal distinctions that an overly general concept can conceal.

Empirical findings are accompanied by numbered references to the bibliography at the end. Observation, statistical association, experimental intervention, and the authors’ interpretations are distinguished. A study can show how people behave under certain conditions; it cannot, by itself, establish what they are obliged to do. The proposals concerning education, institutions, and the distribution of obligations are arguments advanced by the book, not interventions whose effectiveness has already been demonstrated.

The sources were consulted for this text in September 2026. The bibliography includes original works, research ethics documents, and scholarly overviews offering guidance through philosophical disputes. The discussion of God examines concepts and arguments without presenting belief or unbelief as an experimental finding. Legal distinctions and examples of vulnerability are no substitute for a competent assessment of a particular case.

PROLOGUE. The Man Outside the Door

A man sits on the step of a building. It is cold. Beside him are a bag and an empty cup. We do not know whether he is asking for money, waiting for someone, or unable to continue on his way. One resident says it is not his problem. Another says it is the city council's problem. Someone remarks that the man must have made bad choices. A woman asks whether anyone has called an assistance service. A child asks why nobody lets him inside.

The scene is imaginary. Precisely for that reason, we can afford not to invent a biography for the man that determines our reaction in advance. We will not turn him into a professor who happened to end up on the street so that he deserves compassion. We will not assign him an addiction in order to withdraw his right to it. We do not know whether he is generous, irritable, intelligent, or unbearable. We know only that he may need help.

Who is responsible for his situation? The question seems simple until we notice that it conceals other questions. Who helped bring it about? Who failed to meet an obligation? Who can intervene now? Who should bear the cost of intervening? Who ought to prevent the scene from recurring? The answers may point to different people. Someone may not be to blame for another person's exposure to the cold and still have a serious reason to open a door. An institution may have a duty to intervene even though none of its employees caused the misfortune.

We do not ask the child to solve homelessness. But perhaps we ask the child not to throw stones. We do not ask the man on the step to reorganize the economy. But if he can understand and control himself, we can ask him not to strike the person approaching him. We do not ask the resident to turn his home into a permanent shelter. But perhaps we can ask him not to confuse uncertainty with condemnation. We do not ask the official to be omnipotent. We ask him to use the power he has honestly.

Then the question rises to another level. If there is a God who sees everything and can do everything, why should intervention fall to hurried, fragile, poorly informed human beings? If there is no God, where does their obligation come from? Fear? Empathy? A contract? The possibility that tomorrow they might be the ones on the step? And if one of them knows for certain that he will never end up there, does his responsibility disappear?

This book does not begin by assuming that every instance of suffering has someone to blame. Some misfortunes cannot be neatly apportioned between perpetrators and victims. Nor does it begin with the idea that we can live without answering to one another. A society in which every action is merely the effect of causes, and every obligation is someone else's problem, does not automatically become more clear-sighted. It may simply become harder to live in.

I will defend a position: responsibility should be demanded in proportion to a genuine ability to understand and influence a situation, but it is not reducible to blame for the past. Power, knowledge, promises, and participation in institutions can create obligations for the future. These obligations must have limits; otherwise, conscientious people end up paying endlessly for the indifferent. Those limits must, in turn, be justified; otherwise, any privilege can declare itself powerless.

We will not find an instrument that measures blame as a thermometer measures temperature. But we can become more precise in the questions we ask. We can distinguish an explanation from an excuse, a limit from a pretext, an obligation from manipulation. And we can notice something unsettling: sometimes the question "who is to blame?" helps us achieve justice; at other times, it keeps us occupied until there is nothing left to save.

1. When We Say Someone Is Responsible

One Word, Several Processes

An engineer inspects a bridge. A worker installs a component. A director cuts the maintenance budget. A storm strikes the structure. The bridge collapses. The next morning, the public asks who bears responsibility. The question may mean who caused the accident, who should be investigated, who must compensate the victims, or who must ensure that the other bridges do not collapse. A single sentence is trying to do the work of several investigations.

The philosophy of responsibility distinguishes being a cause from being morally accountable. An object can cause a death without being a moral agent. When assessing a person, control and what that person could understand matter, among other things. Nor does an obligation to perform a task coincide with credit or blame for its outcome. Contemporary scholarship separates these questions precisely because they overlap only in part. [1]

In this book, causal responsibility will mean contributing to an outcome. Retrospective moral responsibility will concern the grounds for praising, criticizing, or blaming someone for what they did or failed to do. Role responsibility will concern the tasks attached to a position: parent, researcher, administrator, employee. Prospective responsibility will concern what must be done from now on. Reparative responsibility will concern restoring, compensating for, or acknowledging harm. These are working distinctions, not sealed compartments of life.

There is also legal liability. It depends on rules, procedures, evidence, and institutional authority. We will not deduce it directly from the book's moral judgments. An act can be legal and still reprehensible; a moral obligation may not be appropriate for legal enforcement. Asking a friend to be attentive is different from asking the state to punish

him for not being a good friend. Conversely, some compensation mechanisms aim to distribute a risk without declaring the person required to pay a bad human being.

We can now take the bridge case apart. The worker installed the component, but perhaps he was given defective material that the inspection required of him could not detect. The financial director never touched the structure, but perhaps she eliminated an inspection she knew was necessary. The engineer may have done everything that could reasonably be asked and still be the person best placed to organize urgent inspections. Her obligation for the next day does not establish her blame for the previous one.

The distinction protects us from two symmetrical injustices. The first is scapegoating: we seek out the person closest to the outcome and place the entire chain of causes in their arms. The second is the disappearance of obligations into complexity: because nobody controlled everything, we conclude that nobody owes anything. Between them lies the difficult work of identifying each person's contributions, warnings, duties, alternatives, and actual power.

There is also responsibility as a character trait. We call someone responsible when we can rely on them. But trust needs an object. An accountant can be exceptionally consistent in administering a fraud. An official can flawlessly carry out an unjust procedure. Reliability and morality are not identical. To call a person responsible in a richer sense, we must also care about the things for which they consider themselves accountable, not merely the regularity with which they accomplish them.

Finally, publicly accepting responsibility is not necessarily accepting it in practice. "I take responsibility" can precede an explanation, a resignation, reparation, or absolutely nothing. The formula has substance only if it changes the relationship between the speaker and the consequences. Who may ask questions? What information must be provided? What must be corrected? What power may be withdrawn? Responsibility without the possibility of being questioned and without an obligation to change anything risks remaining a verbal ceremony.

Are We the Authors of Our Actions?

Two drivers check a message while driving. Nobody appears in front of the first. A pedestrian crosses in front of the second. The initial negligence is the same; the consequences are radically different. We have reasons to treat the need for reparation differently. But do we have equally strong reasons to believe that the second driver was, at the very moment of choosing, a much worse person?

The debate about moral luck, associated in its contemporary form with Bernard Williams and Thomas Nagel, begins with this conflict. We want moral assessment to concern what depends on the agent, yet outcomes, circumstances, and even part of the agent's character depend on factors they did not choose. The problem is not only the luck of avoiding an accident. It is also the luck of never having been placed in a situation that would have exposed our weaknesses. [2]

We do not know how courageous we are merely because we have not been threatened. We do not know how incorruptible we are merely because nobody has offered us something important. This observation should temper moral triumphalism, not suspend every judgment. Actions remain different. Someone who resisted pressure deserves recognition. But comparing people requires more than comparing their visible outcomes.

The question goes deeper still. We did not choose our genes, family, language, or earliest role models. If every choice comes from a personality shaped by prior causes, where does genuine authorship begin? Incompatibilists hold that certain forms of determination threaten the freedom responsibility requires. Compatibilists argue that an action can be free in a relevant sense if it arises from a person's deliberation and ability to respond to reasons, even in a causally governed world. Simply invoking chance does not solve the problem either: a random movement does not thereby become my choice. [1]

Let us take an example without spectacular metaphysics. One person turns on a tap because he wants water. Another turns it on after someone physically forces his hand. The final movement may be identical. But the explanations differ in how the person participates in producing it. In the first case, his information, purpose, and delibera-

tion play a role. In the second, they are bypassed. Even if both episodes have causes, the difference remains relevant to how we can demand explanations and change behavior.

This does not establish the existence of absolute desert, independent of a person's entire history. It establishes only that the statement "everything has causes" does not by itself erase every distinction between coercion, reflection, manipulation, negligence, and intention. We can reject the idea that someone deserves suffering merely to restore the universe's metaphysical balance while still preserving the protection of victims, the establishment of facts, demands for explanations, and the obligation to make reparation.

Knowledge matters to such demands too. Not having known may be an excuse, but sometimes the failure to check is precisely the problem. The literature calls this the epistemic dimension of responsibility. Not all ignorance is culpable: we must investigate whether the person could have recognized the need to become informed and whether they had reasonable means to do so. A standard that demands everyone foresee every consequence no longer distinguishes a human being from an oracle. [3]

Imagine two people providing the same false information. One repeats, in good faith, a credible announcement they had no reason to suspect. The other ignores three warnings because the truth would undermine their advantage. Correcting the information is necessary in both cases. The reproach need not be identical. Here we see the advantage of differentiated responsibility: it can demand repair without inventing identical blame, and criticize the avoidance of knowledge without punishing the mind's inevitable limitations.

Real, Invented, or Both?

We cannot put responsibility in a container. But neither a promise, a financial debt, nor a marriage is that kind of object. The absence of a separate physical body does not make a concept unreal. Some realities exist through shared rules and relationships. They can change lives even though they would not exist in a universe without beings capable of understanding them.

Yet the fact that a rule exists socially does not establish that it is just. A community can rigorously enforce an absurd obligation. The sociological reality of attributed guilt does not guarantee the moral truth of the accusation. We must therefore separate two questions: do people actually organize the world through responsibility? And are the particular ways they distribute it justified? The first can be investigated through observation, documents, experiments, and history. The second requires arguments about reasons, rights, interests, and the acceptable treatment of persons.

Suppose a village considers a thief's family guilty of the theft, although its members neither helped nor knew anything about it. The norm is socially real. It produces shame, exclusion, and perhaps violence. But precisely its reality makes it open to criticism. We do not need to deny the practice's existence to deny its legitimacy. Much of the moral progress we can imagine consists in this separation: institutions exist, but they are not sacred merely because they function.

Moral realism, constructivism, and various forms of antirealism offer divergent answers about the ultimate status of moral judgments. Broadly speaking, realism holds that moral truths exist; many of its forms regard them as independent of our approval. For a constructivist, their justification depends on how they would emerge from an appropriate rational procedure, not on mere whim. An antirealist may explain moral language through attitudes and practices without accepting independent moral properties. These families contain internal disagreements, and some forms of constructivism may be compatible with realism; the labels do not settle the issue. [4]

We can, however, move forward without claiming to have settled the ontology of all morality. If someone accepts that their own suffering matters, we can ask them to explain why another person's similar suffering should count for nothing. If they accept that other people's promises create legitimate expectations for them, we can ask them to explain why their own promises should be decorative. These questions do not logically convert every egoist. They expose the cost and asymmetry of that person's position. Moral philosophy has no proof that can force everyone to care; it has ways of making a refusal to care harder to hide behind an appearance of neutrality.

I propose treating responsibility as a justifiable relationship between an agent, something that depends on them, and other beings whose interests are affected. “Justifiable” is essential. Not every expectation others have becomes my obligation. A group may demand obedience, a partner may demand that I give up my entire life, an institution may demand silence. The demand must be assessed, not merely recorded.

This working definition rejects both a universe in which every pain automatically conceals a sin and a social universe in which nobody owes anybody anything. It leaves room for unchosen obligations: a dependent child has signed no contract with its parents; someone accidentally struck may need help from the person who struck them; an administrator assumes tasks generated by their position. Not having chosen the whole situation does not mean that all our reactions are equally justifiable.

Responsibility is therefore real at least as a social practice and as a problem of justification. Whether it also exists in the stronger sense of independent moral truths remains a philosophical dispute. But nobody can eliminate the problem merely by saying the word “invented.” Bridges are constructed too. The relevant question is whether they hold, whom they allow to cross, and who is crushed when they collapse.

2. A History of Those Who Must Answer

From Action to Character, from Character to Relationship

Imagine a hearing in which everyone agrees on the facts but nobody agrees on the question. One participant asks what the person did. Another asks what kind of person they became. A third asks which role they betrayed. A fourth wants to know what consequences they could foresee. The history of responsibility is not merely a succession of answers to the same question. It also involves changes in which question is considered decisive.

There is no single genealogy in which humanity departed from superstition and proceeded in an orderly way to the modern rational individual. Different traditions have combined intention, consequence, relationship, law, and character. Disputes have existed within the same tradition. We will follow several conceptual turning points without turning their selection into a complete history of the world, and without assuming that our vocabulary was already that of ancient authors.

In Book III of the *Nicomachean Ethics*, Aristotle examines voluntary actions, coercion, and ignorance. The difficult cases are “mixed”: the person who throws cargo overboard to save the ship makes a choice, but in circumstances they would not have wished for. The analysis does not allow every act to be reduced to free choice or the complete absence of choice. It calls for examining particular circumstances and what the agent knew. [5]

This observation remains fruitful. A worker accepts a risky task to avoid losing income. Nobody physically pushes them into it, but neither are they choosing from a menu of equal possibilities. We can acknowledge the choice without idealizing its freedom. We can criti-

cize conduct without pretending that its author had the same power as the person who imposed the conditions. This middle ground is precisely what discussions of merit often erase.

Virtue ethics also shifts attention toward the formation of the person. An action does not come from nothing: habits, ways of noticing, and practical judgment contribute to it. In the Aristotelian tradition, practical wisdom does not mean instrumental skill alone. Someone can calculate very well how to achieve a bad end. Understanding what is worth pursuing is part of the problem. Yet virtue ethics is not alone in valuing character, just as rule-based ethics does not automatically ignore consequences. [6]

From this perspective, a society concerned with responsibility cannot regard education as simply transmitting prohibitions. It must ask what kinds of people its rewards produce. If it admires success regardless of the means, it cannot be sincerely surprised when concern for the means weakens. This is a normative criticism of its consistency, not a psychological law according to which every person will copy rewarded behavior.

In the Confucian tradition, moral life is closely connected with relationships, cultivation, and roles. The idea should not be reduced to mechanical obedience. A ruler's conduct and moral example matter, and relationships involve expectations of several parties, even if they are not organized according to contemporary egalitarianism. A role describes not only what you may ask of others but also what you must become to fulfill it properly. [7]

Mencius uses the case of a child at risk of falling into a well to discuss spontaneous compassion. He also connects good government with the material conditions under which people can cultivate a moral life. In ancient Chinese debate, this differentiated concern for those close to us encountered the challenge of impartial concern associated with Mozi. We therefore have no single "Eastern mentality," but a dispute about the relationship between affection, order, and obligations toward strangers. [8]

The dispute still concerns us. A parent who favors their child at their own table is not doing the same thing as an official who favors that child in a public selection process. A relationship can create a special

duty in one context and a conflict of interest in another. History offers more than ornamental wisdom here: it forces us to acknowledge that the same apparent virtue, loyalty, can protect a vulnerable being or defend an injustice.

Duty Before a Visible or Invisible Judge

People have also located accountability beyond immediately visible relationships. If actions have moral consequences within a cosmic order, escaping the community's sanctions does not close the case. This idea can limit the powerful person's arbitrariness: winning does not automatically mean being right. But it can also encourage the interpretation of misfortune as deserved punishment. The two uses must be separated, even when expressed in the same religious vocabulary.

In Indian Buddhist traditions, intention plays a central role in assessing action and understanding karma. These traditions connect moral practice with reducing suffering and transforming mental dispositions. They cannot be compressed into the slogan that every suffering person has received exactly what they deserve. The doctrines, interpretations, and their relationship to compassion are more complex than a popular accounting of cosmic rewards. [9]

We can independently formulate a test for any religious explanation of suffering. If the explanation makes me more attentive to what I can repair, it has a certain moral function. If it authorizes me to refuse help because I assume the victim is guilty in some invisible history, it requires an extremely strong justification. It is not enough that the explanation cannot be disproved. The very inaccessibility of the evidence should prevent us from using it as a verdict on another person's life.

Belief in God as judge does not produce a single conception of responsibility either. We can conceive of obedience to a command, accountability for intention, fidelity to a covenant, or the obligation to care for the vulnerable. We can also conceive of the protest of someone who suffers without acknowledging the guilt attributed to them. The Book of Job, to which we will return, makes it impossible to reduce all religious reflection to the formula "you suffered, therefore you deserved it." [10]

The tension between imposed law and justifiable law reappears in another form in Kant. Moral autonomy does not mean doing whatever you wish, but considering yourself bound by principles you can rationally uphold, not merely by your immediate interests. The formula of humanity requires that we not treat a person merely as a means. Universalization asks whether the rule by which we act can also be upheld when it does not benefit us. These ideas do not automatically turn every dilemma into a simple calculation. [11]

Think of an employer who says he can conceal a risk because workers need their wages. He uses their very vulnerability as an instrument for securing acceptance. A perspective centered on respect for persons asks whether consent can still perform its purported moral function when important information is deliberately withheld. The signed contract does not exhaust the issue. Sometimes the paper records an agreement; at other times, it certifies an asymmetry that the signature does not heal.

John Stuart Mill's utilitarianism places the well-being of those affected at the center of assessment, rather than the prestige of the decision-maker's intentions. Happiness and suffering do not become relevant only when they belong to the agent. Mill also discusses justice, rules, and motivation; he does not propose simply satisfying every impulse that produces immediate pleasure. Nevertheless, the orientation toward consequences leaves open the difficult question of sacrificing some for the benefit of others. [12]

We should not hastily choose here between two caricatures: the rigid person who follows the rule and lets the world burn, and the accountant who justifies every cruelty with a convenient total. The rule protects precisely because it cannot be suspended for every local advantage. The consequence matters precisely because the victim is not saved by the purity of our intention. Mature judgment must bear this tension rather than replace it with a slogan about good intentions or good results.

When the World Becomes Too Large for a Single Conscience

In a small community, you can see the person affected by your gesture. In a large organization, you see a task, an indicator, a stage. The person affected may appear much later, in another place, in another department. This distance must not be confused with the absence of a connection. Sometimes the division of labor distributes expertise; at other times, it also distributes the possibility of no longer seeing the overall result.

Durkheim analyzed solidarity based on similarity and the solidarity of a differentiated society in which people depend on one another's functions. For him, the division of labor was not merely a matter of economic efficiency but also a problem of integration and moral regulation. His analysis does not oblige us to approve every existing order. It helps us notice that an individual's everyday autonomy may depend on a social network they never encounter in its entirety. [13]

The interpretation proposed here is this: the more indirect dependence becomes, the more explicit the means of seeing obligations must be. We cannot rely solely on the emotion of an encounter. Someone inspecting a facility may never know the people protected by their work. That does not diminish the inspection's value. A responsible society must make contributions that prevent harm without producing a heroic story both intelligible and worthy of reward.

In his 1919 lecture on politics, Max Weber placed the ethic of conviction and the ethic of responsibility in tension. One emphasizes fidelity to commitment, the other acceptance of an action's foreseeable consequences. The distinction should be read neither as a license for cynicism nor as an obligation to abandon every principle. The problem is how someone can act in the world without hiding their effects behind inner purity. [14]

A leader who announces a generous reform but refuses to examine its implementation does not demonstrate generosity by ignoring failure. Conversely, a leader who continually justifies injustice through "realism" does not demonstrate responsibility merely by counting constraints. Conviction needs to confront the world; the analysis of con-

sequences needs moral limits. Without the first correction, idealism can become indifference to effects. Without the second, pragmatism can become a technique of efficient domination.

Nietzsche challenged the presentation of guilt and punishment as transparent expressions of an obvious moral order. His genealogy investigates the relationships between morality, power, debt, and the formation of conscience. It does not follow that every moral criticism is false or that vulnerable people do not matter. What follows is an uncomfortable question for any institution distributing blame: whose interests are served by the precise way it has defined it? [15]

Ethics of care brought dependence and the work needed to sustain life to the fore. Carol Gilligan, Nel Noddings, Eva Feder Kittay, and Joan Tronto contributed in different ways to this shift in emphasis. Care is neither a feminine biological essence nor the abandonment of justice. One of its political questions is who provides care, under what conditions, and who can afford to appear independent because someone else takes care of their needs. [16]

Through this lens, the image of the self-sufficient adult changes. Someone who devotes their life to ideas may depend on another person who cooks, cleans, cares for a child, or accompanies an ill parent. If we call the first activity a vocation and the second merely a natural obligation, we have already distributed prestige and burden. Responsibility concerns more than who did wrong. It also concerns who maintains the conditions under which others can succeed.

Technological power adds a problem the book will follow to the end: effects can extend beyond their authors' lifetimes. We need not assume that we can control the future to recognize that we can narrow the options of those who will inhabit it. The history of responsibility thus remains open. It moves from the question "what will happen to me because of what I did?" to the question "what might happen to others because we can do so much?"

3. The Child, the Adult, and the Mind That Cannot

When Does Obligation Begin?

A child breaks a glass. The adult asks why the child was not paying attention. Later, the same adult breaks another glass and says it was placed too close to the edge. The difference does not necessarily lie in the facts. It may lie in who has the authority to interpret them. Education in responsibility begins in a place where adults' responsibility is already being tested.

A child is neither a miniature adult nor a being incapable of any moral participation. We must distinguish the ability to notice a need, understand a rule, anticipate a consequence, resist an impulse, and explain a choice. They need not all be present to the same degree for a child to participate in putting something right. But their partial absence makes automatically applying adult standards unjust.

In a study published in 2006, Felix Warneken and Michael Tomasello observed instrumental helping behavior in children around eighteen months old in situations where an adult encountered a practical difficulty. The finding matters because it shows that some forms of orientation toward another person's goal emerge very early. It does not demonstrate that a child already possesses adult morality, that helping is free of all social influence, or that altruism will dominate in every situation. [17]

A child can pick up a dropped object and still not understand why they must wait, why a secret can hurt, or how someone excluded from a group feels. Helping with a simple task is not equivalent to being accountable for distant social consequences. That is precisely why we should use neither the early emergence of helping nor difficulties with self-control as an all-encompassing argument. The former does not make education unnecessary. The latter do not make the child's participation pointless.

A reasonable educational proposal is to assign responsibilities according to the task and available support, rather than a global label. A child may have the task of putting a toy away, but the adult must make the place accessible. The child may help repair damage but is not obliged to manage the adult's anger. The child can be taught to say what happened but must not be threatened until they produce the desired confession.

Let us compare two reactions to the broken glass. In the first, the adult says that only a careless, bad child does such things. In the second, the adult makes sure nobody gets hurt, asks what happened, and involves the child, according to their abilities, in putting things right. The second reaction does not guarantee a superior moral character. But its structure is more justifiable: it connects accountability with the action, offers a way to participate, and does not turn a mistake into a permanent identity.

Is there a right to make mistakes? Not an unlimited right to hurt others. There is, however, a strong reason to create situations in which learning mistakes are possible, detectable, and repairable. We cannot demand the development of independent judgment while forbidding every opportunity to exercise it. An education that controls every choice may secure compliance; it has not yet tested whether it has developed responsibility.

Here a more difficult task arises for the adult: sometimes accepting an uncomfortable answer. A child who asks why a rule is unjust is not automatically irresponsible. They may be beginning to distinguish authority from justification. If education teaches children that good is whatever the more powerful person says, it should not be surprised when they later justify an action by saying they were told to do it.

A child's responsibility must therefore grow with the ability to participate, but also with the right to be heard. Assigning tasks alone, without offering explanations or recognizing limits, means constructing obedience under the name of maturity. Withdrawing every task for fear of asking too much means postponing precisely the experiences through which children might learn to take responsibility.

The Child Is Not Responsible for the Adult's Life

“After everything I have done for you” can introduce a legitimate request for gratitude. It can also introduce an endless debt. The parent provided care and now demands the choice of profession, partner, or entire way of life. Past care is transformed into a title of ownership over someone else's future.

The child did not ask to be brought into the world. It does not follow that all their subsequent relationships are free of obligations. It does follow, however, that basic care cannot be treated as a loan taken out by an absent debtor. A relationship can generate affection, gratitude, and, later, mutual help. It does not automatically justify unlimited submission.

Responsibility for providing care must not be confused with responsibility for guaranteeing the happiness of the person receiving it. A parent can do serious and reasonable things without being able to control all the child's suffering. An adult child can support a parent without being able to cure every dissatisfaction. The distinction matters because an impossible obligation can become an instrument of domination: whatever the other person does, there is always another pain for which to blame them.

A responsible school should teach this limit too. Sometimes a pupil needs to learn that they may ask for help, that they need not mediate every family conflict, and that a more powerful person's mistake does not become their fault. This is a proposal for the moral organization of education, not a diagnosis of any particular family. Applying it requires attention to context and competent support when there is a real risk to the child.

At the same time, protection must not become the elimination of every contribution. Helping care for the home or showing consideration for a tired parent can be a natural form of cooperation. The criterion is not whether a task exists, but whether it suits the child's abilities, whether it avoids sacrificing their fundamental needs, and whether the adult retains responsibility for adult life. A child can help at the table without becoming the family's emotional administrator.

In school assessment, responsibility can also get lost in numbers. A pupil has a poor grade; the conclusion is that they did not try hard enough. That may be true. But the grade alone does not establish the explanation. The teacher must distinguish the outcome, effort, understanding, access to support, and how the task was designed. Nor should difficulty automatically become a general excuse. A proper investigation avoids both reflexes.

Suppose a pupil submits a text produced by an AI system and presents it as her own work. Calling her lazy is not enough, just as saying technology makes the situation inevitable is not enough. What requirement was communicated to her? Which part was she supposed to do herself? What forms of help were permitted? Did she understand the difference between assistance and false attribution? If she understood and deliberately concealed it, there is an issue of honesty. If the rules were unclear, the institution also has something to put right.

A better assessment can require explaining decisions, discussing sources, and revising an error. It does not eliminate every form of cheating. But it shifts the emphasis from the appearance of a flawless product to the ability to answer for it. That would be a deeper educational objective than producing pupils who know how to give the expected answer but cannot say why it should be believed.

Moral maturity does not begin when a child no longer needs anyone. Such a moment may not exist even for adults. It begins when their participation becomes more clear-sighted: they recognize effects, can offer reasons, accept correction, and help put things right without believing that every mistake excludes them from the community.

What Do We Owe Those Who Cannot Be Held Accountable?

The expression “cannot think” gathers together profoundly different situations. One person may be unconscious. Another may have significant cognitive difficulties but be able to express preferences. Someone may not understand a complex decision yet understand a close relationship perfectly. Another has the capacity to reflect but

does not use it at a particular moment. Placing all these situations in the same category is already a moral error before it becomes a practical one.

We must separate a person's worth, their decision-making capacity, and their accountability for an action. Worth is not measured by intellectual performance. Capacity must be discussed in relation to a task and context, not automatically inferred from someone's prestige, diagnosis, or vocabulary. Accountability for an act requires examining the relevant ability to understand and control it. Someone may need support in one area and participate autonomously in another.

The 1979 Belmont Report sets out a twofold requirement for research involving human participants: respecting autonomy and protecting people whose autonomy is diminished. The document connects consent with information, comprehension, and voluntariness. It is not a complete theory of all human relationships, but it shows why respect is reducible neither to abandoning someone before an impossible choice nor to having someone else take over all their choices. [18]

Imagine a woman who cannot compare the terms of a complicated contract on her own but knows where she wants to live and with whom she feels safe. Needing help with the contract does not erase her preferences about her life. Justifiable support tries to make the choice intelligible and possible. Abusive control uses the difficulty as a pretext for no longer asking her anything.

There are situations in which deliberation or expressing a choice is impossible. The question then shifts toward protection, interests, known preferences, and limits on the power of those deciding. We cannot derive approval from silence for whatever suits us. Nor can we pretend that procedure disappears because the person cannot request it. On the contrary, an inability to contest makes safeguards and the possibility of independent oversight more important.

But why should someone have rights if they cannot have reciprocal obligations? If we base all morality on exchange between equal partners, the question becomes uncomfortable. A newborn cannot pay for care. An unconscious person cannot promise gratitude. Someone with

profound limitations may never be able to participate in negotiating the rules. A morality that excludes them for this reason would make bargaining power the condition of worth.

The position defended here is that the need for protection should not depend on the ability to provide something in return. Vulnerability does not, by itself, establish the entire architecture of rights, but it constitutes a serious reason for care. If a being can be affected, what we do to it must be justified. Its lack of accountability is not our lack of responsibility toward it.

This does not mean that every dangerous behavior must be allowed to continue. Protecting others and protecting the vulnerable person may require intervention. But the justification must be connected with necessity, proportionality, and competent assessment, not a wish to punish guilt the person could not have incurred. A diagnosis establishes neither the absence of responsibility nor dangerousness. A particular attribution requires a particular assessment.

Finally, refusing to think is not the same as being unable to. Someone who deliberately avoids relevant information to preserve an advantage may be accountable precisely for that avoidance. Nevertheless, the possibility of knowing and the avoidability of ignorance must be established, not inferred from our dislike. “You should have known” is a serious accusation. It must be accompanied by an explanation of what the person could have learned, how, and at what cost. [3]

The test of a society is not only how severely it judges those who can be held accountable. It is also how it protects those unable to construct a convincing defense. Listening only to eloquent people would be a very efficient way to confuse voice with worth.

4. The Homeless Man and the Night-Shift Worker

How Free Is a Choice Without Good Alternatives?

Someone is late for an appointment and loses an important opportunity. We can say they should have organized themselves. Perhaps so. But before issuing a verdict, we should find out whether they had somewhere to sleep, could charge their phone, knew the route, and had to choose between the appointment and an urgent need. This information does not automatically turn lateness into a virtue. But it changes what “should have” means.

When discussing the responsibility of a homeless person, two simplifications are common. The first reduces the person to a succession of bad choices. The second reduces them to a victim without any initiative. The first hides the constraints. The second hides the person. Both spare us the effort of understanding a particular life.

The terms are not interchangeable either. Asking for money on the street and lacking a stable home do not necessarily describe the same situation. Neither condition alone provides information about honesty, intelligence, or intentions. In this chapter’s scenarios, we will discuss people whose circumstances must be understood, not a human type to whom we could assign an entire psychology at a glance.

Research by Anandi Mani and colleagues, published in 2013, investigated the relationship between material deprivation and performance on cognitive tasks. The studies included prompting thoughts about financial problems and comparing the same farmers before and after harvest. The authors interpreted the findings as indications that financial pressure can consume cognitive resources. They did not establish any inherent intellectual inferiority among poor people. The designs do not permit generalization to every person and situation; seasonal comparisons are not equivalent to randomly assigning poverty. The article also received a methodological criticism published in the same journal, followed by a response from the authors. [19, 20, 21]

The moral relevance is more modest and more useful than the slogan “poverty makes you incapable.” An apparently simple requirement can demand resources an observer considers free only because they possess them. Keeping a document requires a safe place. Answering a call requires a working phone. Thinking long-term requires that tomorrow not be entirely consumed by the problem of survival. These are conditions for certain actions, not universal excuses for every deed.

Let us compare declining an appointment for convenience with missing it after a night without shelter. The administrative outcome may be identical: the person did not show up. But a system that reacts identically may confuse uniformity with fairness. Not every difference in treatment is favoritism. Sometimes it is the necessary adjustment that makes it possible to follow the rule in reality.

There is an opposite danger. If we assume that someone in difficulty cannot decide anything, we take away precisely the opportunity to rebuild their life. Consulting them does not mean attributing control over the whole context to them. It means not using that context to remove them from their own story. Support can expand the alternatives and leave the choice in their hands where that is possible.

Responsibility for one’s own life makes sense as participation in what can still be changed. It becomes cruel when used as a complete explanation of what happened. Someone can be encouraged to keep their documents, honor an agreement, and avoid hurting others. These requirements do not imply that homelessness is deserved punishment. Nor does the success of someone who overcame a difficult situation establish that everyone who failed is to blame.

A good test would be to ask what concrete alternatives the person had. Not a heroic alternative we can imagine after the event, but one that was accessible, intelligible, and reasonable at the time. What information did they have? What did they risk? Who depended on them? This test does not guarantee leniency. Sometimes it will show that a better choice existed. But at least it will judge a real choice, not an observer’s idealized freedom whose cost the observer never paid.

Must Help Be Earned Through Innocence?

Suppose now that the man on the step really did make serious mistakes. He refused help, lied, and hurt people close to him. Is preventing him from freezing less urgent? We can regard certain acts as condemnable while also refusing to turn homelessness into a punishment without an end date.

Emergency help and assessment of the past serve different purposes. If we mix them, every encounter with a vulnerable person becomes a summary trial. The passerby would have to decide, within seconds, whether an unknown biography is clean enough. Such a criterion is not merely harsh. It is impossible to apply fairly and favors well-told stories over actual needs.

A rule for providing help can nevertheless have conditions. Other recipients and staff must be protected. Violence or exploitation do not become acceptable because their perpetrator suffers. The question is whether a condition actually protects something important or merely asks the person to prove they deserve to be treated as human. A safety limit, a rule for living together, and a test of moral purity are not the same thing.

A randomized study published by Sam Tsemberis, Leyla Gulcur, and Maria Nakae in 2004 compared a Housing First program with an approach conditional on stages of treatment. The program provided housing and support without first requiring abstinence or adherence to treatment. The research, with 225 participants initially assigned, found advantages in housing stability and perceived choice. It detected no between-group differences in substance use or psychiatric symptoms. Interpretation requires caution: exclusions occurred after randomization, and the population and context were specific. The finding supports a bounded intervention, not the idea that housing automatically solves every difficulty. [22]

The experiment nevertheless opens a moral question that the data alone cannot decide: why do we sometimes treat the conditions necessary for stability as rewards to be received only after stability has been achieved? If housing helps someone keep appointments and organize their life, refusing it until they become organized can create a

circle. This argument alone does not establish the best policy for every city. It shows what should be compared and tested in place of an assumption about character.

A critic may reply that unconditional help risks encouraging harmful behavior or distributing resources unfairly. The objection deserves examination. We should ask which behaviors, with what measurable effect, and compared with what alternative. Conditions have costs too: administration, excluding eligible people, interrupting support. Identifying a risk of helping is not enough; it must be compared with the risks of refusing help.

There is also the problem of the person who works hard and can barely pay for housing. They may perceive support given to others as unjust. A serious response is not to despise their dissatisfaction. It is to ask why their security is so fragile and whether the system leaves them too close to the same precipice. Solidarity becomes difficult when people are offered only a choice between their own insecurity and their neighbor's.

This book's position is not that every form of help is good. It is that a person's worth should not depend on success in a contest of innocence. We can require behavior compatible with others' safety, evaluate programs, and correct abuses without turning a basic need into a moral privilege.

And the homeless person may, in turn, have responsibilities toward someone more vulnerable at that moment. They may notice someone who has fallen, warn a child, or refrain from exploiting another's trust. Responsibility does not descend only from respectable people toward those being helped. It arises wherever there is a relevant ability to respond. Recognizing that ability is also a form of respect.

The Worker Who Sees the Risk but Cannot Stop the Factory

At the end of a shift, a worker notices an irregularity. He knows that reporting it may stop production. He also knows his boss rewards people who "do not create problems." He is unsure how serious the risk is. He has loan payments, dependents, and few employment al-

ternatives. Can we ask him to speak up? Usually, we have reasons to require at least a reasonable step. But what counts as reasonable also depends on the protection the organization offers him.

Professional responsibility has a component connected with competence. Whoever performs a task must pay attention to its relevant risks. But it also has an institutional component: the person must be able to report, investigate, and escalate a problem. An organization cannot reserve decision-making power for management and transfer all blame to employees for what they lacked the power to stop.

Let us distinguish three situations. In the first, the worker knows of a clear danger, has a functioning procedure, and can report it without disproportionate cost, but hides the problem for a bonus. In the second, he reports it repeatedly and management ignores the warnings. In the third, the information is incomplete and the procedure ambiguous. All three can lead to the same accident. They do not produce the same distribution of responsibility.

“I was following orders” is not a universal excuse. But “you could have refused” is not a complete argument either. We must establish what refusal entailed, how serious the harm was, how clear it was, and what other avenues existed. The more serious the foreseeable harm and the more direct the participation, the stronger the moral pressure to refuse. Nevertheless, a society that systematically relies on heroism from those with the least power and then abandons them has not solved its problem of responsibility.

A reporting channel makes sense only if it changes something. A form can record a report and bury it. A procedure can protect the institution from scandal without protecting people from risk. Morally, what matters is whether the message reaches someone able to decide, whether it is investigated, whether the whistleblower is treated fairly, and whether the outcome can be tracked. We are not discussing particular legal rights here, which depend on jurisdiction, but the function of an institution that claims to listen.

There is also an opposite limit: not every employee can be given an unlimited veto over the entire organization merely because they invoke a risk. Fears may be mistaken, information incomplete, conflicts real. Responsibility therefore requires procedures for investigation

and decision, not replacing managerial authority with the authority of any suspicion. An alarm must be taken seriously without automatically being declared true.

Management's responsibility is greater not because managers are a different moral species, but because they have access to information, can distribute resources, and can change rules. If they impose deadlines incompatible with inspections and then punish the person doing the work for a foreseeable error, they have not discovered an individual defect. They helped construct its conditions. Evidence would be needed to support this accusation in a real case; the scenario shows only the logic of attribution.

Decently performed work also has a positive dimension, easily overlooked in a book about blame. Maintaining a safe service, explaining a limitation to a customer, properly handing over a shift, and leaving usable documentation are forms of care toward strangers. They do not always require heroism. They require continuity, skill, and conditions in which these are possible.

The night-shift worker and the homeless man do not represent two species, one responsible and the other dependent. They represent different positions in the distribution of security, options, and power. A serious concept of responsibility must see those differences without turning either person into a mere illustration of a social theory.

5. The Crowd, the Citizen, and the Invisible Hands

Why Does Nobody Help—and Why Might the Question Be Wrong?

Someone collapses in a railway station. Twenty people are nearby. Each sees that the others see. Each might assume someone else has already called for help. A photograph of the scene could become evidence of modern indifference. But the photograph does not tell us who intervened a moment earlier, who is looking for a phone, who has not understood what is happening, or whether the situation is actually an emergency. Moral judgment needs more than a convincing frame.

In John Darley and Bibb Latané's classic experiment, published in 1968, participants heard someone apparently having a seizure over a communication system. Intervention depended on how many other witnesses they believed were present. The study helped formulate the idea of diffusion of responsibility: the perceived presence of others can weaken the feeling that you, specifically, must act. Yet this was a precise experimental situation, not a definitive X-ray of human character. [23]

A meta-analysis published by Peter Fischer and colleagues in 2011, involving more than 7,700 participants and 105 independent effect estimates, found an overall bystander effect: the likelihood of individual intervention could decline in the presence of others. But the results depended on context. In situations perceived as dangerous, the effect was attenuated; others could also represent support, not merely an excuse for passivity. [24]

A very different investigation requires further caution. Richard Philpot and colleagues analyzed 219 recordings of public conflicts in three cities. At least one bystander intervened in approximately 91% of incidents. More bystanders were associated with a higher probability

that someone would help. The study concerned visible conflicts in monitored spaces, not every imaginable emergency, and did not establish that every intervention resolved the situation. [25]

The two kinds of finding do not automatically contradict each other. The probability that a particular person will help is not the same as the probability that at least one of those present will help. Ten people, each less willing, may together offer more chances of intervention than a single person. The exact relationships depend on their interactions; the logical distinction remains valid.

This difference also changes the moral discussion. We cannot infer from the existence of diffusion of responsibility that crowds are inevitably cruel. Nor does the frequency of helping in certain conflicts mean we can comfortably rely on someone else. Describing a mechanism does not grant an individual an exemption. It shows where coordination can fail and where it is worth building.

Let us return to the station. One bystander explicitly asks whether help has been called. Another answers. A third looks for station staff. The situation is resolved not by a sudden increase in everyone's virtue but by turning a diffuse obligation into identifiable actions. This is a hypothetical example, not a universal recipe for emergencies. The general idea is that responsibility sometimes needs a clear sentence before it needs a moral speech.

The same problem arises in public administration. A report reaches five departments. Each registers it; none is tasked with checking the final outcome. All can demonstrate that they followed their procedure, while the affected person remains without an answer. The failure need not be explained exclusively by officials' malice. It may be produced by an organizational structure that distributes activities but not the obligation to follow their consequences.

Hence a simple institutional requirement: for foreseeable problems, there must be a connection between a report, a decision, and verification. Someone must be able to say not only "I passed it on" but also "I checked what happened." That person must be given time and authority. Naming someone responsible without providing the necessary means is an elegant way to prepare a scapegoat.

Yet clarity of roles must not produce indifference outside them. “It is not my department” can be useful information or an abdication. The difference depends on what follows: do I point to a functioning route or close the conversation? I do not owe a solution to every problem I encounter. I may owe its proper transfer when doing so is simple and abandoning it would cause foreseeable harm.

The Order, the Uniform, and the Promise That Someone Else Knows

Another scene: a participant believes that, at a researcher’s request, he is administering electric shocks to someone. Stanley Milgram’s 1963 experiment became one of the best-known images of obedience. In the classic condition, 26 of the 40 male participants proceeded to the maximum indicated level. The shocks were not real, but participants had not been told this. The figure of 65% describes that condition, not a universal proportion of people willing to torture. [26, 27]

The interpretation of the experiments remains debated. Stephen Reicher and Alexander Haslam have argued that identification with the scientific purpose and the experimenter’s authority explains some findings better than the image of completely blind obedience. Experimental conditions produced important variations. This reinterpretation does not establish that people are immune to authority; it challenges an overly simple explanation of how authority works. [27]

For responsibility, the difference is crucial. Someone may participate in harm not only by abandoning every moral purpose but also by adopting a supposedly higher one: progress, saving the organization, the group’s security. “We are doing this for good” can close down scrutiny of the means at precisely the moment it should intensify it.

Suppose a team accepts a minor violation to save an important project. Then a second arises, justified by the investment already made. By the end, members see themselves not as people who chose wrong, but as people who defended something valuable against obstacles. The scenario does not establish how frequently this happens. But it shows why sincerity of conviction is insufficient to justify action.

Responsible authority must allow itself to be challenged without turning every objection into betrayal. At the same time, a team cannot function if every decision remains suspended until every member is completely convinced. The solution is not the absence of authority but differentiating decisions: some require rapid execution, others independent scrutiny, and some must be stopped when serious signs of harm appear. These thresholds must be considered before the crisis, not improvised afterward to protect management.

Groups can also support responsibility. Robert Sampson and colleagues' research on "collective efficacy" linked trust among neighbors and willingness to intervene for the common good with lower levels of neighborhood violence. The Chicago study was observational: associations, even after statistical adjustments, are not equivalent to experimental evidence that simply increasing trust automatically produces safety. In his later analysis, Sampson also emphasizes resources and the wider context. [28, 29]

The moral conclusion is not that residents of a poor neighborhood are to blame for failing to produce enough solidarity. That would conveniently invert the problem. Cooperation requires material conditions, time, stability, and institutions that deserve a measure of trust. Asking neighbors to compensate alone for the absence of public services means privatizing a collective obligation.

Nor is solidarity good by definition. A tightly united group can protect an aggressor, exclude a newcomer, or conceal abuse to preserve its reputation. We must ask not only how much people cooperate, but for what purpose and against whom. Mature collective responsibility requires bonds strong enough for action and rights solid enough to limit group pressure.

A good community is not one in which nobody can say "no." It is one in which a reasoned refusal can become useful information rather than evidence of impurity. Sometimes the person who temporarily weakens a group's apparent unity protects precisely the conditions for cooperation worth preserving.

Citizenship Is Not a Certificate of Innocence

A citizen says: “I did not decide. I did not sign. I did not benefit.” Sometimes all three claims are true. The question is whether it follows that there is nothing left for that citizen to do. It does not automatically follow, because responsibility for the future is not identical to blame for the past.

Philosophical discussions of collective responsibility distinguish attributing actions to a group from distributing obligations among its members. They also examine whether organizations, not merely individuals, can be responsible agents. There is no unanimously accepted solution. One important point, however, is separating the obligation to remedy a common problem from the assumption that every member personally committed the same injustice. [30]

Suppose a city spent decades building services that exclude people with reduced mobility. A new resident did not design the steps, refuse funding, and perhaps did not even know about the problem. That person is not the author of that past. But as a participant in current institutions, they may have reasons to support transforming them. The obligation need not be grounded in inherited guilt; it can be grounded in the present need to build an accessible order.

Likewise, benefiting from an advantage created through injustice does not automatically make you morally identical to its perpetrator. But it may matter to how the costs of repair should be shared. This is a thesis requiring arguments and evidence in each situation: what advantage persists, who bears the disadvantage, what measure would actually correct the problem, and whom would it burden? Historical labels alone do not answer these questions.

Citizenship involves a further difficulty: nobody can understand every public issue in depth. Someone working long hours, caring for another person, and struggling with difficulties of their own does not have the same capacity to become informed as a well-funded institution. Requiring universal expertise before recognizing their right to an opinion would be a form of exclusion.

Yet lack of expertise does not justify every kind of conduct. There is a difference between not knowing a case and confidently spreading an accusation you have made no effort to verify. We can require proportionality between what someone knows, how categorically they speak, and how much influence they wield. The same rumor shared in a private conversation and promoted by an organization with a large audience does not create the same situation of responsibility.

A society cannot depend solely on impeccable citizens. It needs rules limiting the harm caused by foreseeable mistakes, intelligible public information, and opportunities for correction. Institutions should not be designed for a fictional citizen who is infinitely attentive, perfectly rational, and always rested. Nor should they be designed for a citizen treated as permanently incapable of judgment.

There is also responsibility for not accepting every obligation claimed in the community's name. A state may demand unjust sacrifices, a majority may demand a minority's silence, and an organization may confuse loyalty with obedience. Answering to others does not mean surrendering the right to ask who makes the demand and who benefits from it.

Responsible citizenship is therefore neither complete withdrawal into private life nor permanent mobilization. It is limited but real participation in maintaining our shared world, accompanied by the right to refuse abusive demands. How extensive that participation should be remains an open moral question. The fact that we cannot set a perfect quota does not make every contribution optional.

6. What Do We Owe Those Who Suffer?

The Child in the Water and the Stranger Beyond the Screen

You are hurrying to a meeting. In a shallow pool, a child is in danger. You can pull the child out without serious risk to yourself, but you will ruin your shoes and arrive late. Almost all the force of this example lies in the disproportion: something grave for another can be prevented at little cost to you. You did not push the child. You promised nothing. Yet your absence from the initial causal chain hardly seems enough to justify walking away.

Peter Singer uses such a thought experiment in his 1972 essay “Famine, Affluence, and Morality.” The central idea is that we have an obligation to prevent a significant harm when we can do so without a morally comparable sacrifice. He challenges the justificatory force of distance and of the fact that others could also help. The example puts pressure on the customary boundary between duty and optional charity. [31]

But the pool is a deliberately simplified case. We see the person, understand the danger, and know reasonably well what effect our action will have. When help passes through organizations, logistical chains, and institutions, questions of effectiveness, cost, and consequences arise. These differences do not automatically cancel the obligation. They change what must be learned to fulfill it responsibly.

Let us replace geographical distance with technical distance. On a monitor, you see someone in danger in another building. You can activate a reliable protective mechanism with a single button. If the image and mechanism are reliable, being unable to touch the person hardly seems to weaken the requirement to intervene. Physical distance alone is not a sufficient moral reason. Uncertainty and limits of control may be relevant reasons.

There are several paths toward the obligation to help. One begins with the significance of suffering: what is terrible for me does not become unimportant merely because it happens to someone else. Another begins with the reciprocity of vulnerability: we have reasons to support a world in which people are not abandoned in grave dangers that others can easily reduce. A third begins with existing ties and promises. We need not necessarily choose one basis for every case.

A distinct path is reparation. If I contributed to harm, the demand to help is no longer merely a vulnerable person's appeal to a stranger. It includes a connection to my action. A manufacturer who concealed a defect cannot present fixing it as an act of generosity. That would turn a duty toward those affected into an occasion for public admiration.

Likewise, a position can create a special obligation. Someone who agreed to supervise a dangerous space is not in the same position as a passerby. The contract does not produce the situation's entire morality, but it changes others' justified expectations. A promise and a role make some needs concern us more directly.

A weaker argument says we must help because we too might someday need help. It is useful as an exercise of imagination but insufficient as an exclusive foundation. What, then, do we owe someone who will never be able to return our help? Or a being unable to participate in an exchange? If the reason disappears entirely when reciprocity becomes impossible, we have described mutual insurance, not the whole moral obligation.

Science cannot cross this threshold on its own either. It can study pain, the effects of poverty, or the consequences of a support program. To conclude that we have a duty, a normative premise is also required: that certain interests of others matter to what we are permitted to do. Such a premise can be defended, criticized, and compared with alternatives. But it does not appear as a laboratory finding between two columns of measurements.

That is why the question "why should I care?" has two meanings. It may ask for reasons for an action in a particular situation. Or it may reject from the outset any reason that does not serve self-interest. In the second case, no fact about the intensity of suffering will produce

an obligation on its own if the interlocutor refuses to recognize any value beyond personal advantage. The dispute becomes one about what kinds of justification we accept between persons.

Arguments Against Unlimited Duty

The strongest objection is not “others do not matter” but “my life matters too.” If every resource must be directed toward the greatest existing need, what remains of the freedom to have a family, investigate something without immediate utility, compose music, or simply live without providing a public justification for every hour?

A defender of a strict separation between negative and positive obligations may say: I must not hurt you, but it does not follow that I owe you my labor to repair every harm I did not cause. Taking autonomy seriously would also mean limiting claims on other people’s time and resources. This is an argument about the boundaries of moral authority, not necessarily a denial of compassion.

One possible reply observes that even the prohibition on harming involves costs and coordination. Protecting rights does not come from nothing. Nevertheless, this reply does not establish that every need creates an unlimited claim on anyone. The autonomy objection remains relevant even if we reject an absolute separation between “not doing harm” and “doing good.”

There are also special obligations. A parent has reasons to give their child care they cannot give identically to every child. Promises, friendships, and relationships of dependence raise questions about legitimate partiality: when may we favor someone, and when does the relationship become a pretext for injustice? The philosophy of special obligations offers no single accepted explanation of their origins and limits. [32]

Eliminating this partiality entirely could destroy the very forms of care through which people come to have a secure life. Making it absolute would allow any advantage for one’s own family to justify any harm to strangers. Between these extremes, we must construct a position in which relationships matter but do not make the rest of the world morally invisible.

The objection of excessive demandingness is also one of accumulation. A small sacrifice may seem obligatory. But what happens when a thousand demands arise, each presented as a small sacrifice? If we assess each request separately, we risk approving a total burden we would not accept when viewed as a whole. Responsibility must also be assessed over time, not only episode by episode.

This observation matters for caregivers. Someone may be the only family member who always responds, and the others may turn that availability into an implicit, endless obligation. The fact that the person can make one more effort does not establish that the distribution is just. When each emergency justifies maintaining the same inequality, emergency becomes a way of organizing exploitation.

Then there is uncertainty about effects. Help can miss its target, create unwanted dependencies, or be diverted. These are possibilities to investigate, not ready-made arguments against every form of support. Conversely, good intention is not evidence of effectiveness. In a particular case, the intervention, alternatives, and costs of nonintervention must be compared. Demanding evidence only of help while treating passivity as free of consequences would be a double standard.

Another objection concerns a person's right to refuse. Perhaps what I call help involves controlling their life. Perhaps I want to remove a risky choice they understand and accept. The anticipated benefit does not automatically cancel autonomy. On the other hand, a refusal expressed without accessible information or under coercion raises different problems. Again, the situation requires discernment, not a single formula.

There are also cases with no obligation to intervene personally: when intervention would create a disproportionate risk, when we lack the necessary expertise and may make things worse, when an urgent obligation to someone else takes priority, or when the demand itself is abusive. These limits are not embarrassing gaps in a perfect morality. They are conditions for addressing obligations to finite persons.

A Real Obligation Without Confiscating Life

The position defended here is that obligations to help exist, but they are not distributed solely according to the intensity of need. Actual capacity, contribution to harm, an assumed role, alternatives, costs, and the power to change the situation also matter. This is a moral proposal, not a conclusion demonstrated by an experiment.

When harm is grave, help is reliable, and the cost to me is low, the requirement to act is strong. When I have produced or sustained the harm, the obligation to repair it may require greater sacrifices. When I have accepted a protective role, I cannot invoke a simple freedom to concern myself only with my own projects. When the problem exceeds individual capacity, the institutional distribution of the burden must be discussed.

The fact that others also have obligations does not automatically cancel mine. But their ignoring those obligations does not automatically transfer everything else to me. This second sentence is essential. Without it, morality would reward the less scrupulous with additional freedom and punish the more attentive with unlimited work.

A decent society must turn some indispensable help into predictable services rather than leave it exclusively to the mercy of fortunate encounters. This does not by itself determine the state's precise form, taxation levels, or the combination of public institutions, organizations, and informal support. It establishes a requirement of justification: lacking the good fortune to encounter a benefactor should not alone determine access to fundamental protections.

Responsible help must be open to examination from the recipient's perspective. What problem do they consider urgent? What do they lose by accepting the offer? Can they challenge the conditions? Are they treated as a person or as material for the donor's reputation? An intervention effective by a single metric may remain humiliating or overlook important costs to the recipient.

Measurement should not be rejected either. Without comparisons, we may continue a useless practice for years simply because it gives us the feeling of being good. The problem arises when the indicator is

confused with the complete goal. The number of people contacted is not identical to the number of lives improved; that number, in turn, does not automatically capture every dimension of a dignified life.

The circle of obligation can also be questioned beyond currently living humans. If a being can suffer, its inability to formulate arguments is not, by itself, a reason to ignore its suffering. This is a conditional argument about the moral relevance of sentience, not a solution to every controversy about animals. Likewise, future people's inability to hold us accountable now does not render the foreseeable effects we leave behind morally indifferent.

There is, however, a limit to the claim of speaking for the future. We can invent hypothetical beneficiaries to justify certain injustices in the present. The more speculative the forecast, the more cautious we must be when demanding sacrifices from others in its name. Protecting the future must not become a blank check for current power.

Having a responsibility toward those who suffer does not mean constantly feeling the entirety of their suffering. Emotion can open our attention, but a just distribution of tasks cannot depend only on who is more easily moved. We can build habits, contributions, and institutions that continue to function on days when our compassion is not intense.

Instead of asking whether we can be happy in a suffering world, we can ask more precisely: what help falls to us, what tasks must be shared, and what excuses prevent us from seeing the difference? General guilt is no substitute for the answer.

7. Those Who Know: Researchers, Philosophers, and World Builders

The Researcher Did Not Ask to Run the World

A researcher discovers a powerful method of analysis. It can help identify a disease, but also classify people without their consent. She says: “I produce knowledge. Society decides what to do with it.” The statement contains an important truth: the researcher must not be transformed into the supreme political authority. But it also contains a possible evasion: sometimes the way she produces and publishes the result directly influences who can use it and with what effects.

Responsibility in research begins before the final application. Choosing the question, selecting data, treating participants, describing limitations, and deciding to conceal or communicate an error are already actions with consequences. The researcher cannot control every subsequent use but can control some of the conditions through which others come to believe and act.

The 1979 Belmont Report sets out the principles of respect for persons, beneficence, and justice for research involving human participants. Questions about consent, risks, benefits, and participant selection cannot be replaced by simply invoking scientific progress. The document provides a historical ethical reference point, not a universal legal solution for every contemporary project. [18]

Suppose a study would produce useful knowledge but use vulnerable people because they can more easily be persuaded to accept risks. The possibility that the result might help many people does not eliminate the question of those used to obtain it. Refusing every risk would not be a solution either: research and life involve uncertainty. The question is who decides, with what information, and who bears the costs in relation to the benefits.

There is also the elementary epistemic responsibility not to present mere hope as a finding. An interesting hypothesis may deserve investigation without being called a discovery. A preliminary experiment may produce a signal without demonstrating the mechanism's generality. An honestly reported limitation is not an editorial defect to be hidden to secure funding; it is part of what others need to know to judge the result.

The researcher also has the right not to promise immediate social effects for every idea. Curiosity, conceptual exploration, and studying apparently remote problems can be legitimate activities. Requiring each project to demonstrate its final utility from the outset would confuse responsibility with obedience to the priorities of the moment. Research freedom and its social obligations must be discussed together, not invoked alternately to cancel one side.

One institutional example is the Ethics and Society Review process, described by Michael Bernstein and colleagues in a 2021 preprint. Artificial intelligence projects underwent a review of their social implications before funding. The authors analyzed the first year, involving 41 proposals. Reports of changes to projects are informative, but they do not establish through a controlled experiment that the mechanism reduced long-term social harms. [33]

Such an example also has value in the question it makes practical: what research decision changes after the ethical discussion? If nothing can change, the review risks becoming ceremonial. If it can block any project merely by invoking vague fears, it risks becoming a form of censorship without criteria. A good mechanism must allow arguments, revisions, proportionality, and examination of its own intervention's costs.

Responsibility cannot be demanded only of the individual researcher. A funder who rewards exaggerated promises, a university that tolerates unverifiable results for prestige, and a company that imposes release before evaluation all help shape choices. In a real case, such statements would require evidence. As a moral structure, they show why demanding integrity without examining incentives is insufficient.

Incentives are not a complete excuse either. A system's favoring exaggeration explains the pressure but does not automatically make exaggeration justified. We simultaneously need people who resist misguided demands and institutions that do not turn that resistance into a continuous test of professional heroism.

Does the Ability to Think Bring an Additional Duty?

Imagine a philosopher who can formulate ten elegant justifications for a practice but never asks those who bear its effects. His intelligence is real. His responsibility may be deficient. The ability to construct arguments does not guarantee that you have chosen an honest question or are willing to abandon a convenient answer.

Being able to philosophize may mean education, time, security, and access to conversations in which ideas are taken seriously. Not everyone with this opportunity acquired it exclusively through their own merit. But it does not follow that their entire life belongs to society. It provides a reason to examine how they use an advantage that can influence how others understand their condition.

There is a specific duty not to manufacture respectability for what we cannot defend directly. If an argument serves to present people as dispensable, we must also test it from the perspective of those declared dispensable. If a theory justifies a hierarchy, we must ask whether the same justification would remain acceptable if its author did not know their own place within it. These perspective tests do not decide truth on their own, but they can expose privileges hidden in the formulation.

The philosopher has no obligation to become a universal commentator. Competence in analyzing a concept does not automatically create competence in economics, medicine, or foreign policy. Intellectual responsibility may require precisely a refusal to answer authoritatively where our knowledge is insufficient. Sometimes the most useful thing an expert can say is where their expertise ends.

On the other hand, continually invoking complexity can become a refuge. If an institution demonstrably conceals harm, it is not enough to observe that the meaning of harm is philosophically disputed. Dis-

inctions are useful when they make judgment more precise. They become irresponsible when used to postpone every practical consequence indefinitely, regardless of how clear the evidence is.

Philosophizing responsibly also means exposing the cost of one's own theory. If I defend an almost absolute freedom to retain resources, I must say what happens to people whom voluntary help misses. If I defend a very extensive distribution of obligations, I must say which personal freedoms it limits. A theory presenting only its admirable intentions and leaving the costs to its opponents is not yet a complete justification.

But what about the person unable to engage in this abstract discussion? They need not demonstrate a theory of justice to have the right to just treatment. Intelligence and education can change the speaker's epistemic obligations, not the fundamental worth of the person being discussed. Someone may be unable to explain in sophisticated terms why they are being humiliated and still be humiliated.

Simple speech does not guarantee truth either. Testimony should be heard, not declared infallible merely because it comes from a vulnerable person. Respect means including it in the examination, not turning the person into a symbol others use without checking the facts. Taking someone seriously includes the possibility of dialogue and disagreement.

Finally, there is responsibility for making ideas usable. A text can be precise yet useless to its intended audience. Clarity does not require eliminating difficulties but presenting them without unnecessary obstacles. Anyone who writes about responsibility and hides uncertainties in solemn language risks reproducing precisely the kind of authority they claim to examine.

The Machine Decided. Who Allowed It?

An institution uses an automated system to prioritize requests. Someone is rejected. The official says the score was calculated by the program. The supplier says the institution chose the objective. The institution says experts recommended the method. Each statement may be partly true, and between them the obligation to offer the person an explanation and a route to correction may disappear.

The philosophy of responsibility in computing discusses this “many hands” problem: outcomes arise from contributions by multiple people, organizations, and artifacts. A system’s technical autonomy must not be confused with moral autonomy. Complexity can make attributing harm difficult without that difficulty establishing the absence of any human obligation to design, oversee, or remedy. [34]

In our scenario, the solution is not to choose a single culprit immediately. First, we must know what kind of rejection occurred, what data were used, whether the score suited that purpose, which uncertainties were known, and who could change the process. Otherwise, “the algorithm is biased” can be as vague an explanation as “the user made a mistake.”

Formally retaining a human in the loop does not solve the problem if that person has a few seconds, no additional information, and no power to challenge the recommendation. Their signature can become a piece of moral scenery. Genuine oversight requires the ability to notice relevant errors, stop or change a decision, and receive support when doing so is justified.

Responsibility must be designed before the incident. Who authorizes using the system? Who checks whether the data are appropriate? Who monitors the effects on people? Who can withdraw it from use? Who responds to an appeal? These questions are not a complete technical specification. They are conditions for ensuring that the division of labor does not become a division of evasion.

There are also situations in which nobody could foresee a particular error. Retrospective accusation may then be unjustified, but the obligation to correct the system remains. Discovering a new risk changes what must be done next. Yesterday’s lack of knowledge does not justify tomorrow’s passivity.

How long are creators accountable for uses they did not intend? Not indefinitely and not for every imagined connection. What matters is how foreseeable the use was, how much they facilitated it, what control they retain, and what proportionate measures were available. Neither “just a tool” nor “the author is responsible for everything” resolves these differences.

Dual-use knowledge poses a similar problem. Publication can enable verification, innovation, and the sharing of benefits. It can also enable abuse. Restriction can reduce a risk but concentrate power and block legitimate research. A responsible choice must compare concrete options, including graduated access and independent scrutiny, rather than retreat into a slogan of absolute openness or absolute secrecy.

Could a future artificial intelligence itself become morally responsible? The question depends on capacities such as understanding reasons, controlling conduct, and being able to answer in a deeper sense than generating an apology. We do not establish here whether or when such conditions will be met. If we built an entity with interests of its own and the capacity to suffer, the question of our responsibility toward it would also arise, not just its responsibility toward us.

Until such hypotheses are clarified, attributing moral words to a machine must not function as an automatic transfer of accountability away from institutions. An “I’m sorry” message does not repair an unjust decision. Repair requires access to facts, authority to make changes, and acceptance of costs. These are things organizations must construct, not emotions interfaces must merely imitate.

8. Can Gods Be Held Accountable?

The Creator and Ownership of Creation

Someone sees a child in danger, can intervene at no cost, and does not. We demand an explanation. Now replace that person with a being we say knows everything, can do everything, and is perfectly good. Why should the question disappear? Perhaps we have reasons to change the standard, but that change must be argued for. Otherwise, we would construct a concept of power in which obligations grow up to a point and then disappear precisely when power reaches its maximum.

Before any accusation, we must clarify which deity we mean. A very powerful but limited god does not raise exactly the same problem as an omnipotent creator. An intelligence that initiated the universe without overseeing it is not identical to a providential parent. An impersonal reality called God is not automatically an agent who deliberates and decides. We cannot attribute all these properties to the same concept merely because we use the same word.

Let us first imagine limited gods, with intentions and interests. If they can understand suffering, choose, and have the power to intervene, they seem to enter the space of moral questions. Being more powerful than humans does not, by itself, grant an exemption. A king does not become just because nobody can defeat him. Nor does a god become good merely because contradicting him is dangerous.

Perhaps our obligation toward such gods would be one of prudence: not to provoke them. But prudence and legitimacy are different things. Submitting to avoid punishment does not establish that the order deserves obedience. This distinction also helps us understand human authorities that demand fear be called respect.

In the *Euthyphro*, Plato examines the relationship between what is pious and the gods' approval. Adapted to morality, the question becomes: is something good because God commands it, or does God com-

mand it because it is good? The first direction risks making goodness dependent on will; the second seems to recognize a standard not reducible to command. The modern adaptation is broader than the dialogue's exact problem. [35]

One possible theistic reply says the alternative is incomplete: goodness would be neither arbitrary nor external to God, but connected with his nature. This reply deserves examination in its strongest form. It does not say that every divine whim would become good. It says a perfect being has no such whims. But a new question arises: by what means do we identify that nature as good, and how do we distinguish an authentic command from a mistaken human attribution?

If the answer is that any act attributed to the deity must by definition be called good, the concept risks losing the substance that made it important. "God is good" no longer provides moral reassurance but merely repeats a verbal identity. If goodness retains a meaning we can understand at least partially, then questions about suffering cannot be dismissed merely because they are unpleasant.

Another reply invokes the status of creator. God would have rights over what he made. But creation does not obviously confer an unlimited right to dispose of a being with interests of its own. A parent contributes to a child's existence without turning the child into property. The analogy does not establish that the relationship between God and the world is identical to parenthood. It shows that moving from "created it" to "may justly do anything" requires an additional argument.

A defender of theism may object that all analogies are inadequate: God is not a more powerful inhabitant of the universe but the ground of its existence. The objection is serious. Yet the further we remove the deity from every intelligible category of agent, the harder it becomes to attribute categories such as care, love, justice, or promise without explanation. We cannot use analogy when it offers consolation and automatically forbid it when it produces a critical question.

Calling a deity to account does not necessarily mean claiming that we possess a cosmic tribunal. We can examine whether a concept's properties are compatible and what reasons we have to believe a particular description of the world. Lacking the power to sanction an agent

does not make every judgment about them meaningless. Otherwise, even a perfectly protected tyrant would become morally impeccable merely through the absence of an effective judge.

Suffering as Evidence Against a Promise

The philosophical problem of evil takes several forms. One asks whether the existence of evil is logically incompatible with an omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good God. Another asks whether the scale and distribution of suffering make such a hypothesis less plausible. A defense may show that a contradiction has not been established without offering a convincing explanation for every instance of actual suffering. [36]

The difference matters. Showing that a scenario is possible does not mean showing that it describes the world. A lawyer may show that an innocent explanation for a piece of evidence exists without having proved that explanation. Conversely, not knowing a justification for suffering is not identical to proving that no justification can exist. Serious discussion must avoid both shortcuts.

Let us test the freedom hypothesis. A world in which people can choose would also permit bad choices. If every harmful intention were immediately stopped by divine intervention, some forms of autonomy and real consequence would change. This is an intelligible reason not to identify goodness with eliminating every negative outcome. But that reason alone does not establish how much evil freedom requires.

An aggressor can retain his intention and choice even if the door he wants to force holds firm. Saving a victim does not establish that the aggressor's freedom has been canceled in every relevant sense. The free-will defense must therefore explain more than the existence of choice: it must discuss why certain consequences are permitted and why different limits on the power to harm could not exist. This is a conceptual test, not proof that we know how to construct a complete alternative universe.

Then there is suffering that does not appear to result from a moral choice by either the victim or an aggressor. A child's illness and the pain of a being incapable of deliberation cannot simply be explained

through the affected person's freedom. Broader connections may be proposed, but each additional connection requires justification. Moving the explanation somewhere we cannot examine is not enough.

Let us test the hypothesis of a world with stable laws. Responsible action requires some regularity: we must be able to anticipate effects. A universe in which every accident is miraculously suspended would differ from one in which we learn to protect one another. Yet it does not immediately follow that this precise distribution of risks is necessary. Stable rules explain why consequences cannot be arbitrarily eliminated without changes; they do not establish that every alternative set of rules would be worse.

Let us then test the idea of moral development through difficulty. Courage, patience, and solidarity require obstacles. But not every form of suffering produces development, and the person bearing the cost must not automatically be treated as educational material for someone else. If an adult deliberately hurt a child to make a neighbor wiser, we would demand an extremely strong justification. Invoking a higher plan does not eliminate the question of using the victim as an instrument.

The defender may reply that our judgment is too limited to assess the whole. This argument from the limits of knowledge blocks some categorical conclusions. But it has a cost: if divine goodness can look indistinguishable from cruelty to us, what practical substance remains in trusting it? And if our ignorance prevents us from condemning an evil apparently permitted by God, why would it not also prevent us from helping, since that evil might serve an unknown purpose?

A religious position can coherently reply that human duties remain valid even when the meaning of the whole is unknown. This separates the problem of providence from our conduct. Yet the separation must be maintained consistently: cosmic uncertainty must not be invoked to justify passivity before a need we understand sufficiently.

In *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*, David Hume stages a conflict between explanations of the world's order and the experience of suffering. The text is a dialogue, not a set of statements that can be at-

tributed to the author without qualification. One difficulty it explores is the leap from the observed world to firm conclusions about its creator's unlimited goodness. [37]

Omnipotence must not be defined carelessly either. Thomas Aquinas distinguishes divine power from the capacity to realize logical contradictions: an incoherent description does not become a possibility merely because we ask it of an omnipotent being. This clarification excludes some facile objections. But it does not, by itself, establish that every imaginable reduction in suffering would be contradictory. [38]

The conclusion of this examination is not that God's existence has been established or disproved in a few pages. It is narrower: attributing total knowledge, total power, and perfect goodness simultaneously creates a real explanatory burden in the face of suffering. Answers must be assessed by what they explain and what they ask us to accept without explanation.

Job and the Refusal to Call the Victim Guilty

The Book of Job matters precisely because it offers more than the image of a world in which every instance of suffering proves a fault. The friends try to bring his experience back into an intelligible moral order. The ending rebukes them for how they spoke about God. The religious text thus opens a space for challenging convenient explanations of merit, suffering, and authority. We use it not as empirical evidence but as a work staging a moral problem. [10]

The problem remains recognizable. Someone suffers, and those nearby feel a need to explain quickly why. Perhaps the person chose badly. Perhaps they lacked the right attitude. Perhaps there is a lesson. Some explanations may be true in particular cases. But offered without evidence, they chiefly protect the speaker's peace of mind: if the world punishes only identifiable mistakes, the speaker can imagine themselves safe.

Refusing such an explanation does not mean claiming choices have no consequences. It means refusing the move from consequence to a total verdict on a person. Someone may be responsible for part of their situation and still suffer more than that part could justify. They may need help even if their biography is not innocent.

Job also raises the question of the right to protest. Faith can include lament, questioning, and refusing false consolation. Not every moral protest is a simple denial of the deity. It may be a demand that the goodness invoked by faith not be emptied of meaning. Conversely, unbelief does not establish the absence of obligations toward others; it changes how they are grounded.

Restoration at the end of a story does not logically cancel every loss within it. If someone later receives other goods, it does not follow that the lost people and experiences were interchangeable. This argument also applies to promises of cosmic compensation. Compensation can matter profoundly without retrospectively turning every evil into something good.

We can imagine conceptions of the deity that relinquish one of the properties discussed: limited power, limited intervention, or a relationship with the world that does not resemble an agent's governance. These variants alter the problem of evil, but they also alter the religious promise. A God unable to prevent a tragedy is not judged in the same way as one who can prevent it at no cost and chooses not to.

If God exists and we have reasons to believe in a divine obligation, what "holding him accountable" would mean remains difficult to say. It may be a conceptual assessment, a lament, or a questioning religious relationship, not an enforceable procedure. If God does not exist, the discussion still serves a purpose: it forces us to see what connection we assume between power and obligation, without the usual excuses of human powerlessness.

In shared life, people need not resolve this dispute before cooperating. A believer may see helping as a duty toward God; a nonbeliever, as a duty toward the vulnerable being. Ultimate reasons may differ while justified action coincides. Cooperation requires no metaphysical identity, only enough shared reasons not to abandon the person before us.

Perhaps the most uncomfortable question is not whether we can construct a tribunal for God. It is whether we demand that the deity justify suffering while using that same suffering's existence as an inevitable backdrop for our own inaction. Criticism of a cosmic plan does not repair the world by itself. Nor does belief in such a plan absolve us of what we could do within it.

9. Taking Responsibility Without Believing Yourself to Be God

How Much Can an Entire World Ask of One Person?

At the beginning of the book, we seemed to have a question about blame. By the end, we have a problem of distribution: who must notice, explain, prevent, bear costs, and repair? Sometimes the same person must do all of these. At other times, the distribution must differ. A society goes wrong when it seeks a single name for every task merely because it is easier to display.

Let us imagine a map, not a score. A score would promise that we can add power, intention, and need into a single number, then read off the verdict. We have no such validated instrument here, nor reasons to believe every relevant value is perfectly interchangeable. A map helps us see a situation's dimensions without pretending it can resolve them mechanically.

The first dimension is capacity. What could the person understand and control at that moment? We are not asking only what an ordinary person can do under ideal conditions. Pressure, access to information, available support, and the nature of the decision matter. Nor do we turn every difficulty into an exemption: the difficulty must be relevant to the choice under examination.

The second is relevant knowledge. What did the person know, and what did they have reasonable grounds to find out? We do not demand that they predict every imaginable consequence. But neither do we accept deliberately maintained ignorance as innocence. An official who refuses to receive risk reports is not in the same position as someone from whom information was concealed in a way they could not possibly detect.

The third is the connection to the harm. Did we cause something, facilitate it, authorize it, benefit from it, or simply encounter the result? These relationships differ. Benefit can matter when allocating reparat-

ive obligations without proving harmful intent. Causal contribution can exist without blame. And the absence of a contribution does not always eliminate the obligation to provide simple, urgent help.

The fourth is role. Some tasks fall to us because we accepted them or because others justifiably depend on us. But roles have limits and can be unfairly constructed. A position cannot demand every sacrifice, and a social expectation does not become legitimate merely because it has been repeated for a long time. We must ask whether the obligation has a justification that can also be offered to the person bearing its burden.

The fifth is the power to bring about change. A director can amend a rule; an employee can only flag it; a beneficiary may at most lodge an appeal. Asking the same of them would be false equality. Yet power is not measured solely in titles. Whoever controls information, access, or the agenda may wield influence that the organizational chart does not show.

The sixth is cost, considered alongside the severity and urgency of the need. Losing a few minutes is not the same as losing your basic security. Preventing an inconvenience is not the same as preventing serious injury. Neither need nor cost should be described strategically: we do not minimize someone else's sacrifice merely because it would suit us for them to make it.

Finally, those affected must have a voice. They can correct the description of the problem and reveal costs the decision-maker does not see. Listening to them does not mean granting them infallibility or an automatic veto over every collective action. It means not constructing the judgment exclusively from the perspective of the person with the power to impose it.

The map produces questions, not automatic verdicts. In the case of the child who broke a cup, capacity and the educational purpose matter greatly. In the case of the company that concealed a defect, knowledge, contribution, and power carry a different weight. In the case of the passerby who can prevent serious harm at little cost, an obligation may exist without any prior role. No single ingredient explains everything.

Shared responsibility does not always behave like a pie, either. Discovering that an organization has a serious obligation does not imply that every individual automatically has a smaller one. The institution may need to repair the system, while the person may need to tell the truth about what they did. These are different obligations, not competing percentages of the same unit of blame.

Reparation Is Not a Ceremony of Humiliation

After harm has occurred, the public may demand a culprit, the victim may demand safety, the organization may demand an end to the scandal, and the accused may demand to be heard. These demands are not identical. Some are compatible; others conflict. A responsible process must distinguish them before announcing that “justice has been done.”

First comes protection. If a risk continues, it may be necessary to restrict an activity before establishing all retrospective responsibilities. But a preventive measure should not automatically be presented as a verdict of guilt. Its justification concerns risk and proportionality, and its conditions must be reviewed when new information emerges.

Next comes the truth about the act. Who did what, under what conditions, with what knowledge? A compelling moral story can emerge before the evidence. An accusation does not become truer because it fits our beliefs about a group. Nor is a person's good reputation sufficient to refute a specific accusation.

Then comes reparation. Sometimes this may mean returning property, correcting a decision, funding support, or publicly acknowledging an injustice. At other times, nothing equivalent can undo the loss. Acknowledging this limit is more honest than turning a sum of money or a statement into a compulsory end to suffering.

Apologies have value when they identify the act, acknowledge its effect, and connect to verifiable changes. “I regret that you felt hurt” can avoid acknowledging the conduct itself. But even perfect wording is not proof of a transformation. One person may speak awkwardly and make serious amends; another may speak impeccably and repeat the same act.

The victim does not owe forgiveness to make the community feel at peace. Forgiveness may be meaningful to them, but it must not be imposed as the final task of someone already harmed. At the same time, the absence of personal forgiveness does not by itself determine all the future rights of the wrongdoer. Shared life needs criteria that do not reduce every decision to a single emotion, however understandable it may be.

Punishment raises a further problem. It may be defended through desert, prevention, protection, or the reaffirmation of limits. These justifications are not equivalent. If a measure does not protect, deter, or repair, and merely humiliates, its defense must explain why additional suffering would be a good in itself. This book does not resolve the entire philosophy of punishment, but it refuses to confuse severity with moral seriousness.

There is also a legitimate interest in the possibility of returning. A person who has done wrong need not inevitably be reduced to their worst act. This does not require restoring every position or relationship. Some roles demand a level of trust that can be lost. But we must be able to distinguish between a justified restriction on a role and the person's indefinite exclusion from every possible future.

A culture in which every admission of error brings social destruction creates an incentive to conceal. This is an observation about the logic of incentives, not a claim that we can eliminate wrongdoing through leniency. The response to mistakes must make truth and correction possible without turning confession into a license to repeat them.

The same logic applies to institutions. Firing the most visible person is not enough if the rules that contributed to the incident remain intact. Nor is announcing a “culture change” enough without examining individual acts. Serious reparation combines a personal response with changes to the conditions that made the harm possible.

A School and a Society That Do Not Demand Omniscience

A school of responsibility would not teach children only to identify who broke the rule. It would teach them to ask what the rule protects, what information is missing, what can be repaired, and when the rule

itself must change. These are philosophically motivated educational proposals, not a presentation of a program whose effectiveness we claim has been demonstrated in a controlled study.

One exercise could begin with the same event described from several positions: student, teacher, parent, affected classmate. Students would have to explain what changes when new information appears. The aim would not be to find an excuse every time, but to learn the difference between consistency and stubbornly maintaining a verdict after its grounds have disappeared.

Another exercise would separate intention, means, and outcome. Well-intentioned help can cause harm; a good outcome can arise from an imprudent choice. The student would be invited to assess what could have been anticipated, rather than merely rewarding the winner in retrospect. Luck must not become the only teacher of morality.

Collective responsibility should also be practiced without confusing it with shared guilt. If a space is damaged and the perpetrator is unknown, maintaining it may be a shared task, but this does not justify declaring everyone responsible for causing the damage. If a class has an unfair rule, students can help change it without being forced to confess to fictitious guilt.

At the social level, the same education should be supported by institutions capable of learning. An appeal should not be treated solely as an administrative inconvenience. An incident report should allow causes to be examined without predetermining the conclusion. A service must be able to discover when the people it exists to serve cannot use it. These are criteria for moral design, not guarantees that every specific mechanism will work.

Let us bring the book's cases together in a hypothetical situation. A city introduces an automated procedure for accessing support. A homeless person cannot complete the application. An official notices that the problem keeps recurring. The researcher who evaluated the system receives a complaint. A citizen sees only the queue at the counter and concludes that the beneficiaries are irresponsible.

The applicant may have the task of providing information they can obtain and understand. The official may have the task of recording the problem and using an existing support channel. Management may

have an obligation to change the procedure and provide resources. The researcher must examine whether the evaluation overlooked a relevant type of failure. We can ask the citizen not to turn an incomplete picture into a confident verdict. None of these tasks is identical to the others.

If the system was reasonably designed and the problem is new, there may be less blame for its initial occurrence. Once the effect becomes known and can be remedied, the justification for inaction changes. Responsibility is not only an archive of the past. It is also how we respond to information that has just become available.

There remains one's own life. A responsible person is allowed to sleep, to enjoy themselves, to be unavailable, not to read every news story, and not to respond to every request. These freedoms need not be justified solely by making them more productive at helping others. Their life has value to them as well. Including them among the people who matter is not a departure from morality.

But limits must not be used as a formula for disappearing. Between "I cannot do everything" and "nothing falls to me" lies a large space for action. Within that space are promises kept, errors corrected, risks reported, regular contributions, and improved institutions. They are not spectacular every day. That is precisely why a society should not recognize responsibility only when someone makes a dramatic sacrifice.

Taking responsibility without believing yourself to be God means accepting two limits simultaneously. You cannot control the entire world. Nor are you completely outside it. Between the illusion of omnipotence and the comfort of powerlessness lie finite, contestable, yet real obligations. Seeking them honestly is harder than declaring yourself innocent or a savior.

EPILOGUE. The Door Remains Ours

The man outside the door has not, in the meantime, become a simple problem. We do not know all the causes of his situation. We do not know whether he will accept help, what kind of help he needs, or what can be achieved that evening. We have not discovered the biography that would give us the comforting feeling that he unquestionably deserves not to be abandoned.

We can begin with a respectful question and an assessment of the immediate need, without promising what we cannot do. We can seek appropriate support when the situation calls for it. We can avoid turning him into a spectacle. The next day, we can also ask why the only available solution was improvised by passersby. Immediate action and the institutional problem do not exclude each other.

Perhaps one of the people in the building indirectly caused some of the world's injustice. Perhaps another is barely staying on their feet. Perhaps someone helped yesterday and can do no more today. A responsible account does not assume it knows all this at a glance. Nor does it wait to know everything before making any possible gesture.

The child asks why the man is sleeping there. One easy answer would say that people end up where they deserve. Another easy answer would say that no one is responsible for anything, because everything has causes. Both would close the conversation too soon. A more honest answer would begin like this: we do not yet know all the reasons; some concern choices, others circumstances, and the fact that we do not know does not, by itself, tell us what to do now.

Perhaps responsibility is not a hidden property we find inside people, like eye color. Perhaps it is a practice through which we connect power to explanation, action to consequences, and vulnerability to justified demands. This practice can be unjust. It can be used to discipline the weak and protect the powerful. That is precisely why it must be examined, not abandoned.

The reality of suffering does not, by itself, settle every moral dispute. But it places a serious limit on the pleasure of treating everything as a game of concepts. Beyond our formulations, someone bears the consequences. A philosophy of responsibility is worth keeping insofar as it helps us see more precisely who bears them, who can bring about change, and what demand can be justified.

We will not leave this book with our innocence proven. Nor should we leave with the impression that we are personally obliged to repair the universe. Those would be two ways of avoiding the same work: identifying our share, examining it, and fairly distributing the rest.

That evening, someone opens the door. We do not know whether the gesture will solve much. We need not invent a happy ending to recognize its meaning. Sometimes responsibility begins precisely with refusing to demand certainty of a good ending before doing something justified.

How to Read a Study Without Turning It into a Verdict

A psychological finding can change how we judge a situation without delivering a verdict on every person in it. If an experiment shows that a particular pressure changes behavior on average, it does not follow that we know how a specific individual reacted. The group effect and the biographical explanation are different levels.

An experiment compares conditions constructed by researchers. Random assignment, when properly carried out and maintained, can help separate the intervention's effect from other differences between groups. But the conclusion remains tied to the intervention actually tested, the measurements used, and the population studied. After reading, we cannot expand the meaning of a narrow task into “human morality in general.”

Observational research examines differences in the existing world. It can identify important associations and attempt to account statistically for alternative explanations. Yet the fact that two characteristics vary together does not by itself establish causal direction or the absence of other causes. That is why the study of collective efficacy must not be read as a promise that a neighborhood will become safe if residents are simply encouraged to trust more.

A meta-analysis combines findings from several studies, but does not automatically turn their diversity into a universal law. We need to know what types of situations were included, how effects were measured, and how different the conditions are. The average can be useful while variation across contexts remains essential to a practical decision.

The absence of a detected difference also requires care. Simply stating it does not prove that two interventions are identical. The precision of the estimate and what the study was capable of detecting matter. When a study in this book found no differences on a dimension, that wording must not be expanded into a claim that the dimension cannot be influenced in any way.

There is also the question of the unit of analysis. A study of the probability that an individual will help answers a different question from one about the probability that at least one person in a group will intervene. Findings may seem contradictory if the reader shifts unnoticed from one question to the other. Sometimes an apparent controversy is, first of all, a confusion about what was measured.

Finally, a finding can be correct and still be misused. An average difficulty observed in a group does not justify withdrawing the rights of every member. A mechanism of obedience does not absolve every act committed under authority. An effect of material constraints does not turn a person into an object without initiative. Further arguments are needed between description and the moral treatment of people.

Responsible reading thus keeps two questions separate: “What do the data warrant believing?” and “What do we have reason to do in light of them?” The second needs the first, but is not fully contained within it.

A Short Vocabulary of Responsibility

Moral agent. A being to whom we can address reasons and to whom we can attribute actions in a sense relevant to moral evaluation. The exact conditions of this status are disputed; merely producing an effect is not enough.

Morally considerable person or being. Someone whose interests matter in justifying our conduct. Having this status does not necessarily entail the capacity to answer morally for one's own acts.

Causal responsibility. Contribution to bringing about an outcome. It does not automatically entail intention, sufficient control, blame, or an obligation to punish.

Retrospective responsibility. Assessment of what an agent did or omitted to do, and of the grounds for praise, criticism, or blame.

Prospective responsibility. The obligation to act in the future: prevention, protection, verification, or coordination. It can exist without blame for the origin of the problem.

Role responsibility. Obligations attached to a position or relationship. The role must itself be justified and does not automatically override other moral demands.

Reparative responsibility. The obligation to redress, compensate for, or acknowledge harm. Reparation does not mean that every loss can be undone.

Legal liability. An obligation or consequence established within a framework of law and procedures. It is not synonymous with the general moral assessment of a person.

Being accountable. Being open to questions about a decision and required to provide explanations, information, and, where appropriate, corrections. A simple declaration of accepting responsibility does not exhaust this relationship.

Excuse and justification. An excuse may reduce the agent's blame without making the action good. A justification maintains that the action was permitted or required in the circumstances.

Moral luck. The influence of unchosen factors on the situations, consequences, or characteristics for which people are morally evaluated.

Compatibilism. The family of positions according to which a relevant form of freedom and responsibility can be compatible with determinism. It does not assume that every constraint is unimportant.

Culpable ignorance. Ignorance for which there are grounds for reproach, because the agent had the relevant opportunity and obligation to become informed. Not all ignorance falls into this category.

Special obligation. A requirement connected to specific promises, roles, or relationships, distinct from what we would owe any person. The limits of legitimate partiality remain disputed.

Supererogation. A morally good action that exceeds what is obligatory. Where this boundary lies, especially in helping those in need, is one of the book's central disputes.

Problem of evil. The family of arguments examining the relationship between the existence and nature of suffering and certain conceptions of divine power, knowledge, and goodness.

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